User Manual

UNZA Hostel Maintenance Request and Tracking System

University of Zambia — Final Year Project

User Manual

UNZA Hostel Maintenance — report, track and resolve hostel maintenance issues.

This manual explains how to use the system, step by step, for each kind of user. Jump to your section:

- 1. Getting started (everyone)
- 2. Students
- 3. Technicians
- 4. Administrators
- 5. Settings, notifications and dark mode
- 6. Working offline
- 7. Meanings of statuses, priorities and badges
- 8. Frequently asked questions

> The screenshots use sample data.

---

1. Getting started (everyone)

What you need

A phone, tablet or computer with a web browser and an internet connection. No download from an app store is required.

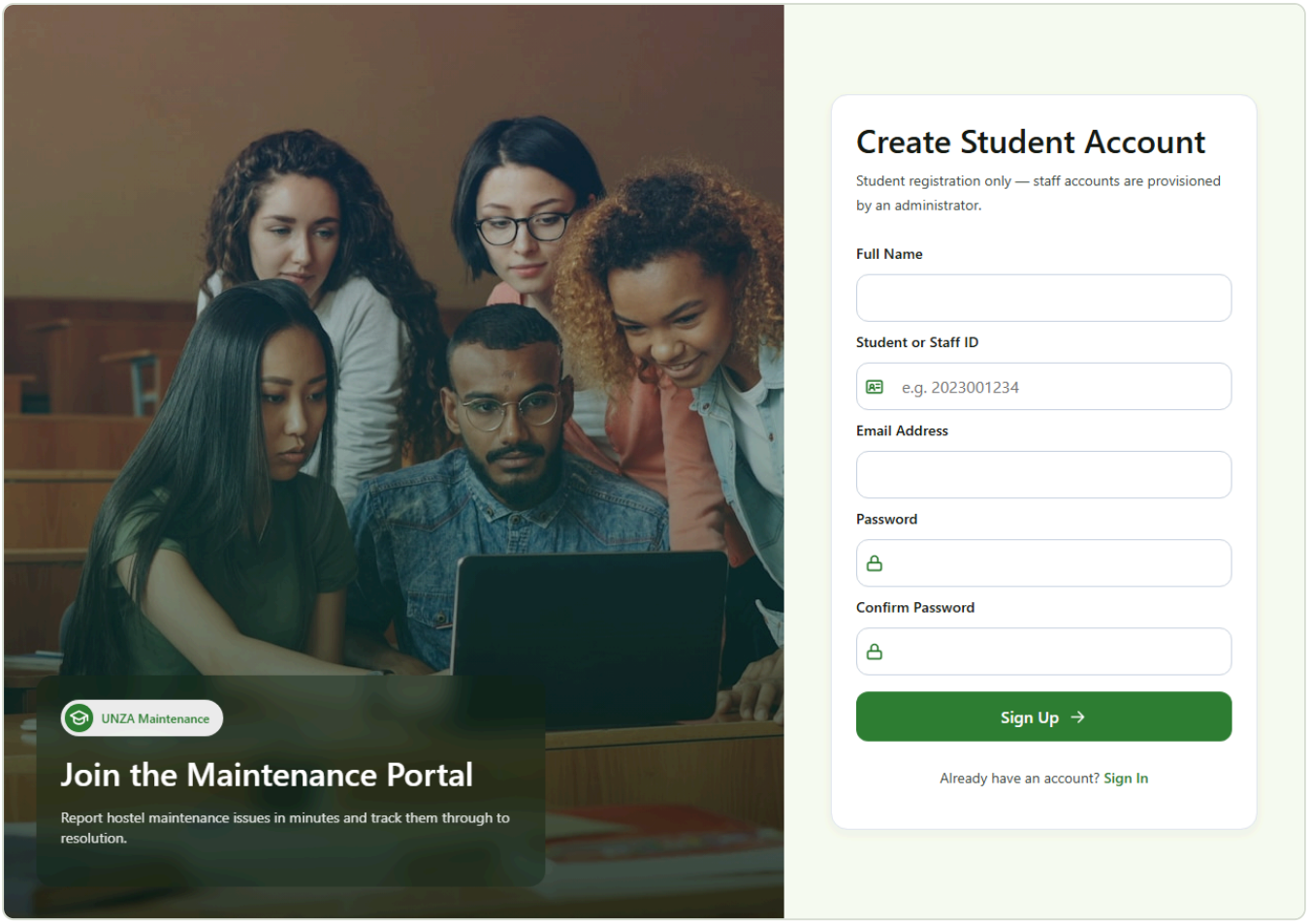
Roles

Role	What you can do
Student	Report faults, back faults others have reported, track your own requests, rate repairs
Technician	See the jobs assigned to you, update their progress, add proof of the finished work
Administrator	See every request, assign technicians, manage staff accounts, view reports

Creating an account (students only)

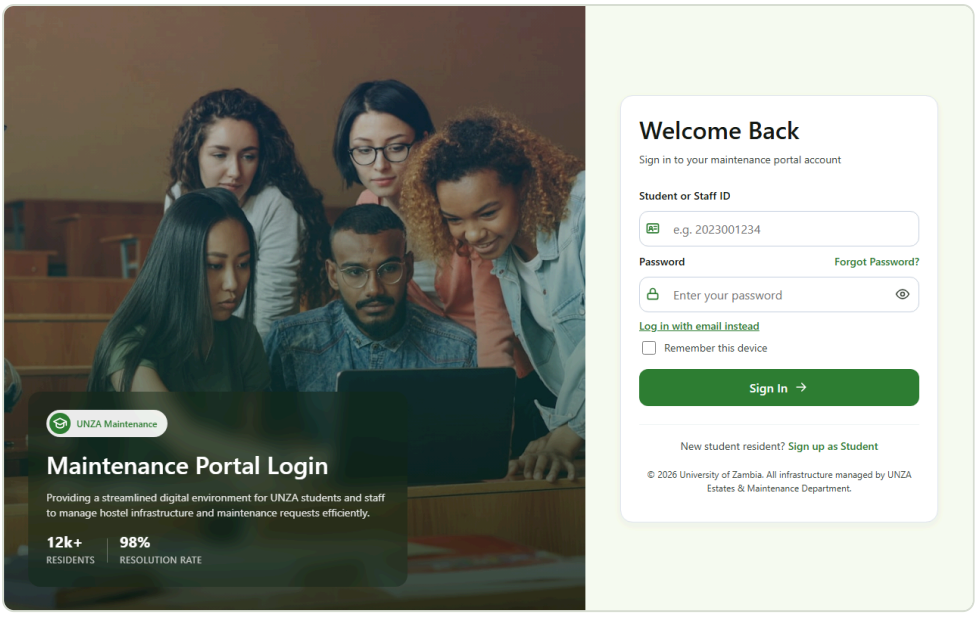
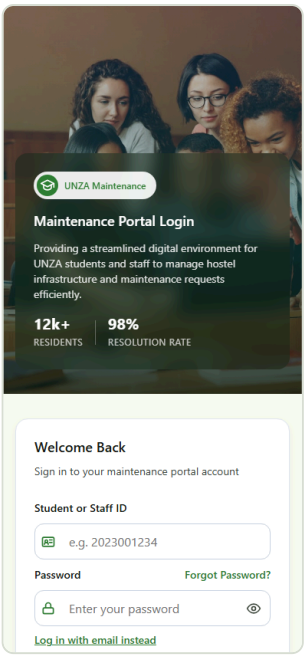
Students register themselves; technician and administrator accounts are created for you by an administrator.

1. Open the website and choose **Sign up as Student** under the sign-in form.
2. Enter your **full name**, **student ID**, **email address** and a **password** (at least 8 characters).
3. Submit. You can now sign in.



Signing in

1. Enter your **Student or Staff ID** and your password, then press **Sign In**.
2. Prefer email? Choose **Log in with email instead**.
3. Tick **Remember this device** on your own phone or laptop so you stay signed in. Leave it unticked on a shared computer.

Computer	Phone
	

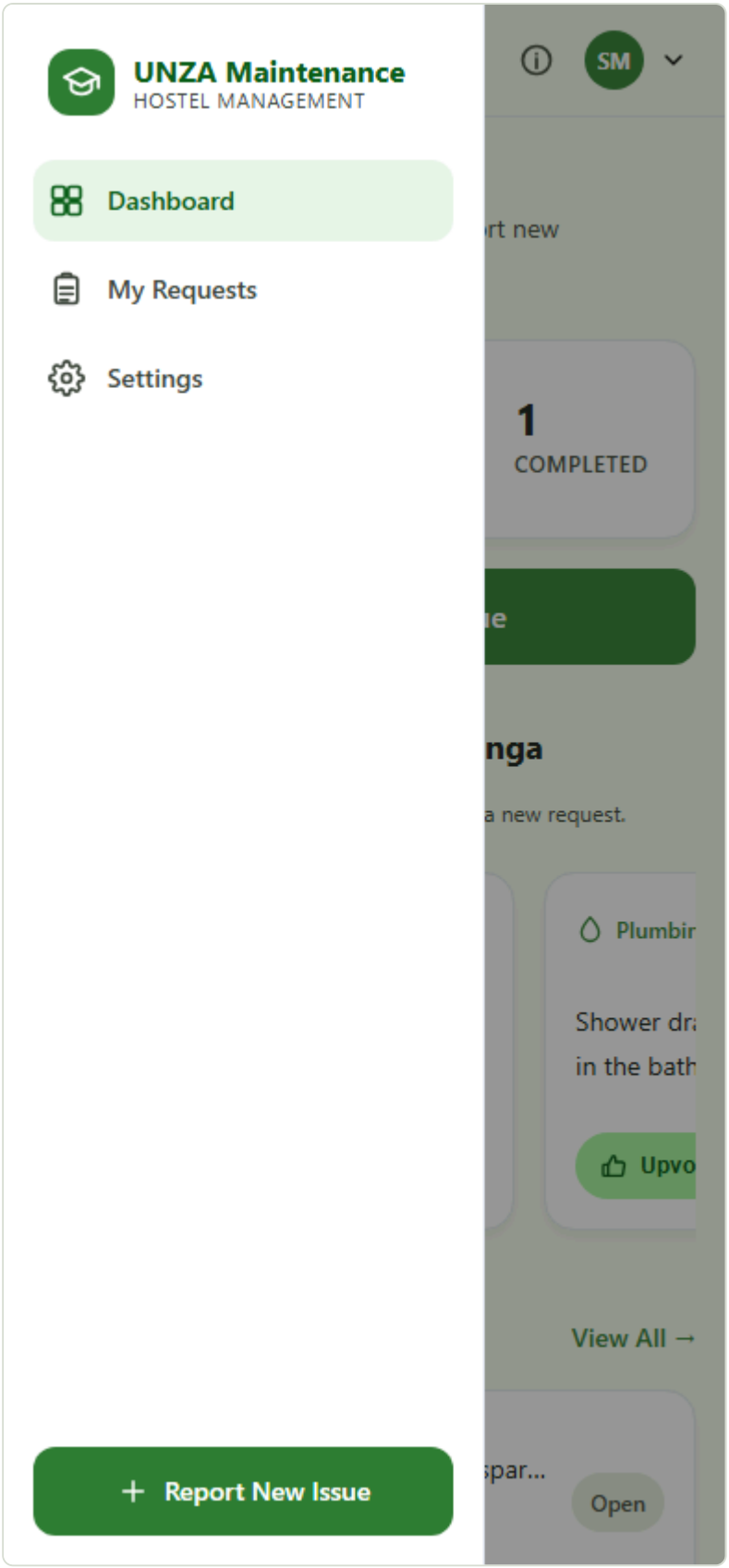
Installing the app on your phone (recommended)

The site is a *Progressive Web App*: you can add it to your Home Screen so it opens like a normal app, loads faster and can send you notifications.

- **Android (Chrome):** open the site → menu (⋮) → **Install app** / **Add to Home screen**.
- **iPhone (Safari):** open the site → **Share** button → **Add to Home Screen**. (On iPhone, notifications only work after you do this.)

Finding your way around

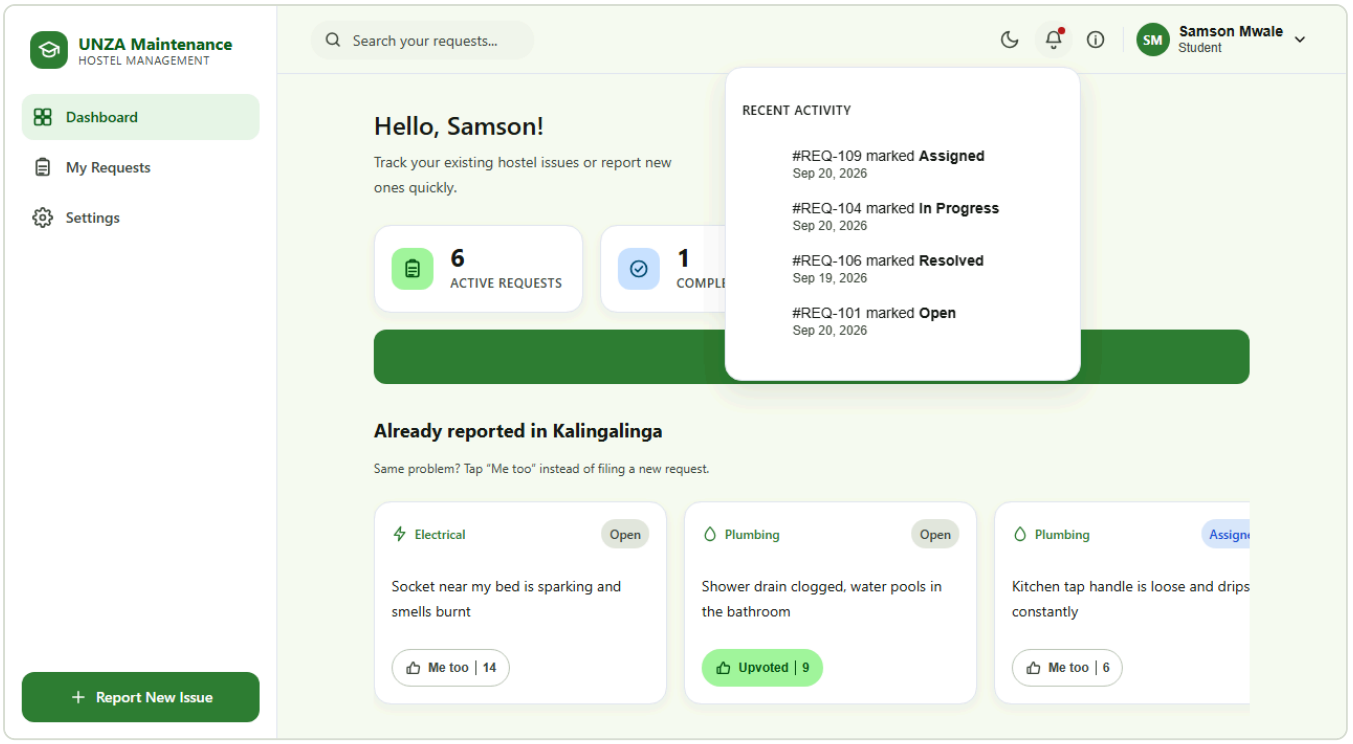
- **Computer:** the menu is on the left; the top bar has search, dark-mode toggle, notifications, help and your profile.
- **Phone:** tap the ☰ button (top left) to open the menu.



The top bar

Icon	What it does
🌙 / 🌞	Switch between dark and light mode
🔔	Recent activity (a red dot means there is something new)

Icon	What it does
ⓘ	Help — a short guide to what each status means
Your name	Profile and sign out

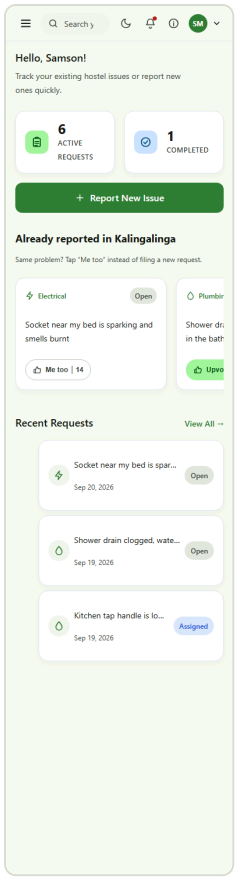
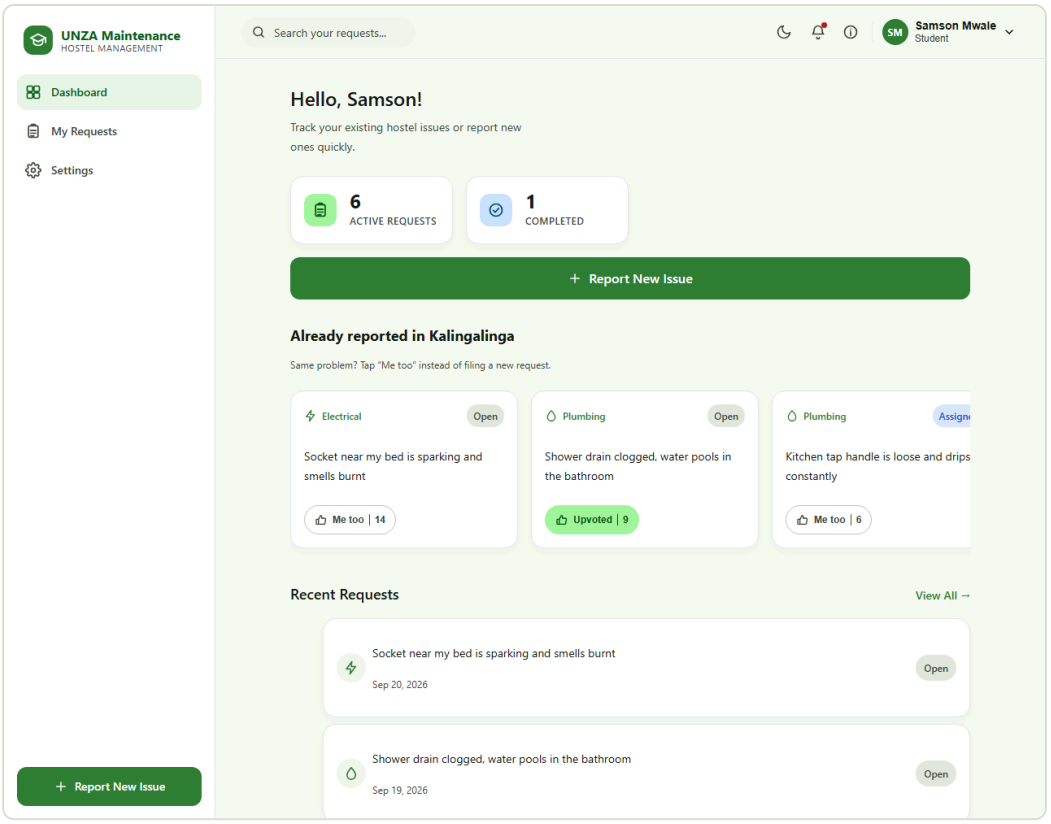


2. Students

2.1 Your dashboard

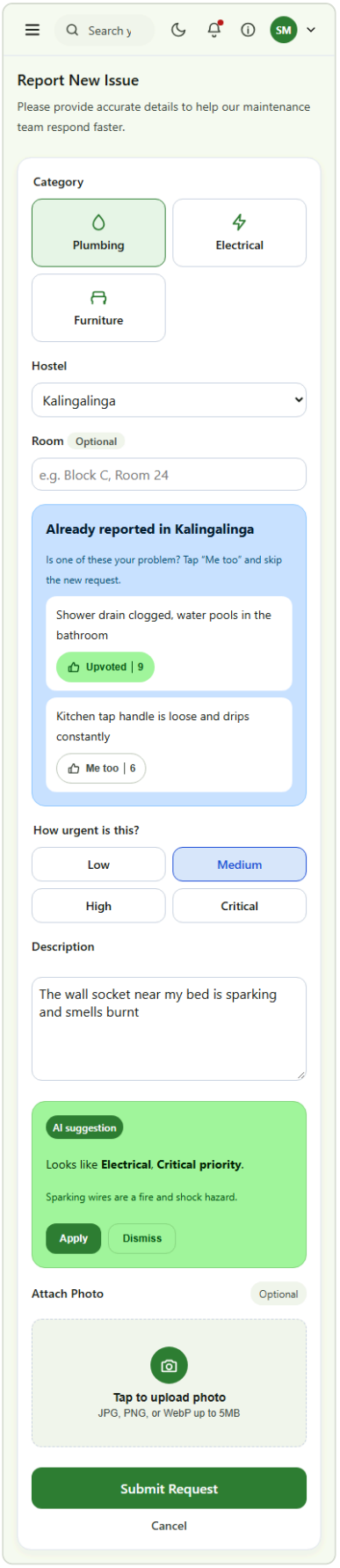
After signing in you see:

- **Active Requests** and **Completed** — how many of your requests are still being worked on or finished.
- **Report New Issue** — the big green button.
- **Already reported in your hostel** — issues other students have already reported (see 2.3).
- **Recent Requests** — your latest requests with their status.

Phone	Computer
	

2.2 Report a new issue

1. Press **Report New Issue**.
2. **Choose a category** (Plumbing, Electrical, Furniture …).
3. **Select your hostel** and, if you like, type your **room**.
4. **Say how urgent it is** — Low, Medium, High or Critical (see section 7).
5. **Describe the problem.** Be specific: "*The tap in the bathroom leaks even when tightly closed.*"
6. *(Optional)* **Attach a photo** — tap the photo area and take or choose a picture (JPG, PNG or WebP, up to 5 MB).
7. Press **Submit Request**.



Two helpers appear while you fill the form:

- **"Already reported in your hostel"** — after you pick a category and hostel, if someone has already reported the same kind of problem you will see it here. If it is *your* problem too, tap **Me too** instead of filing a new request. You help the maintenance team see how many people are affected.

- **A suggestion** — as you describe the problem, the system may suggest a category and urgency ("Looks like Electrical, Critical priority"). Tap **Apply** to accept it or **Dismiss** to ignore it. **You are always in control** — nothing changes unless you tap Apply. Dangerous problems (fire, sparking wires, flooding, burst pipes) are always suggested as *Critical*.

> **No internet?** You can still write the request. It is saved on your device and sent automatically when you are back online (see section 6).

2.3 Back a problem someone else already reported ("Me too")

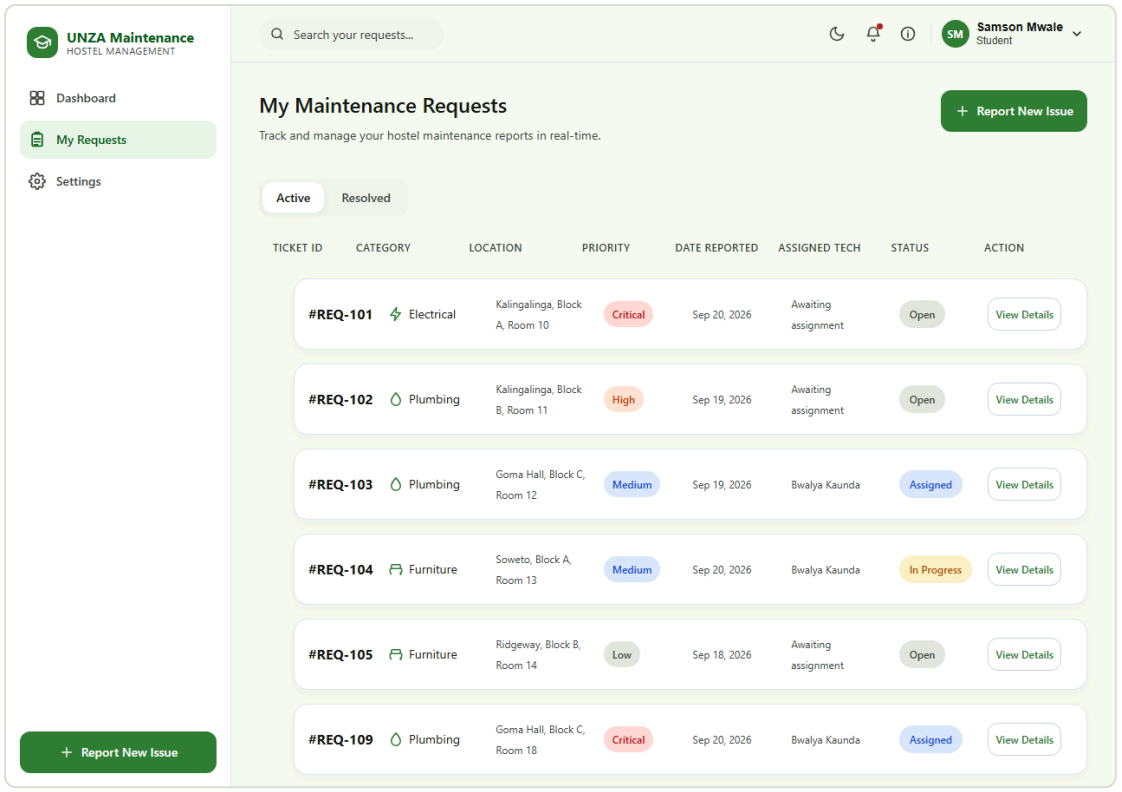
On your dashboard, swipe through **Already reported in** . Each card shows the category, a short description and its status.

- Tap **Me too** if you have the same problem. The button turns green and shows **Upvoted**.
- Tap it again to take your vote back.
- You cannot vote on your own requests, or on ones that are already resolved.
- Other students' names are never shown.

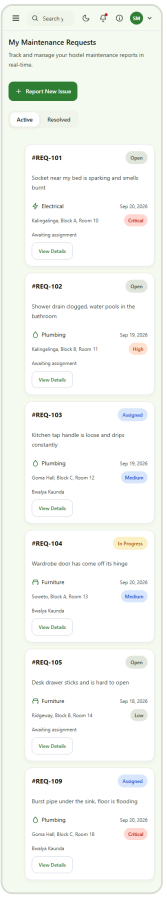
2.4 Track your requests

Open **My Requests** in the menu. Use the tabs to switch between active and finished requests, or the search box in the top bar to find one.

Computer

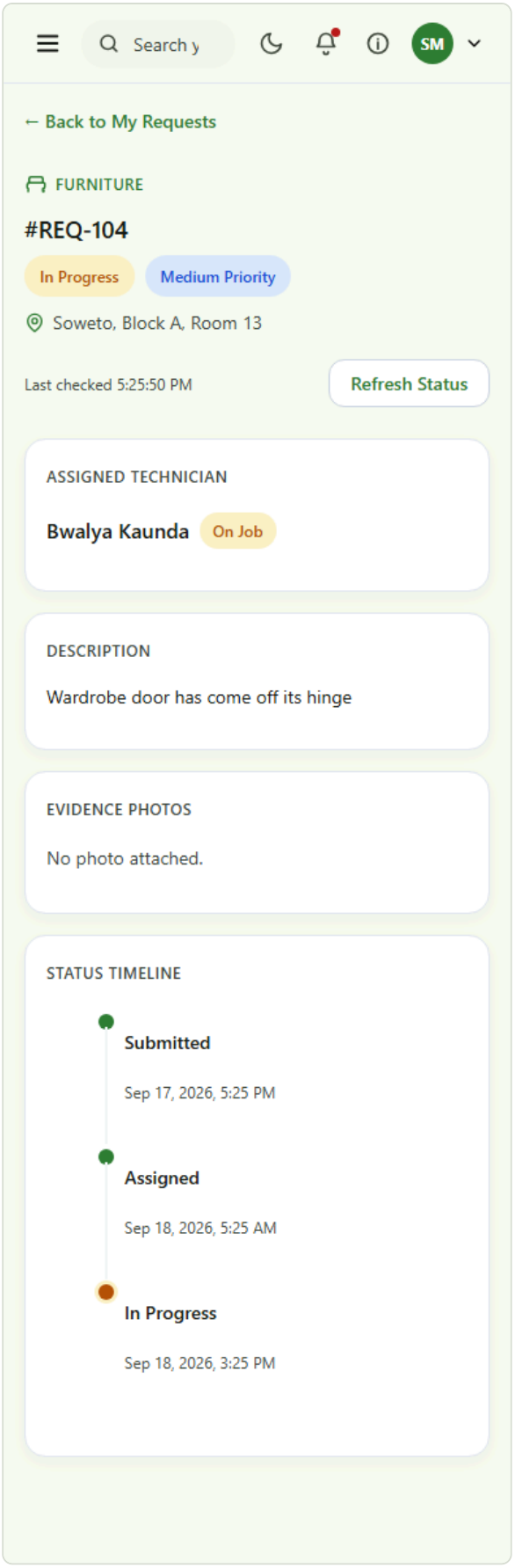


Phone



Tap any request to see its full page:

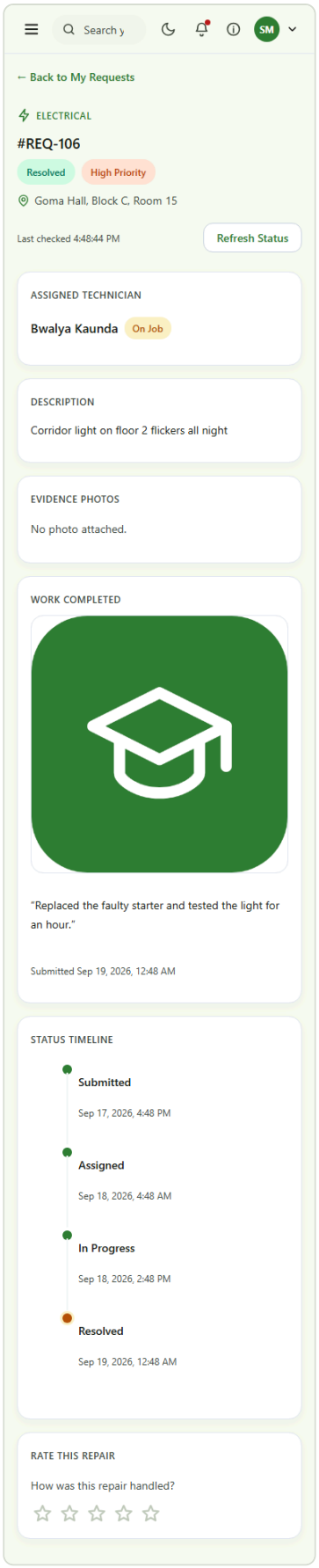
- the **status** and **priority**,
- who is **assigned** to fix it,
- a **timeline** showing every step with dates,
- for finished jobs, a **Work Completed** section with the technician's photo and note.



The page updates by itself when something changes — you do not need to refresh. You can also press **Refresh Status**.

2.5 Rate a finished repair

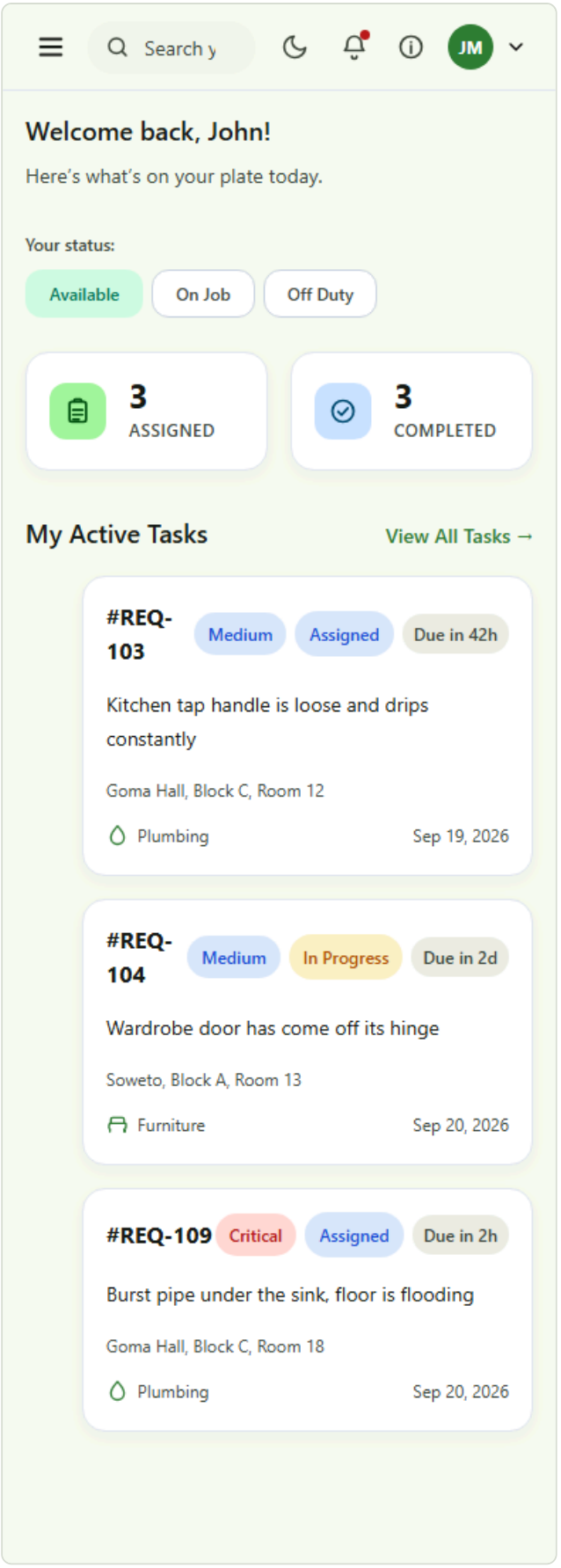
When a request is **Resolved** or **Closed**, the request page shows **Rate this repair**. Tap 1–5 stars (5 is best) and, if you wish, add a comment. You can rate each request once.



3. Technicians

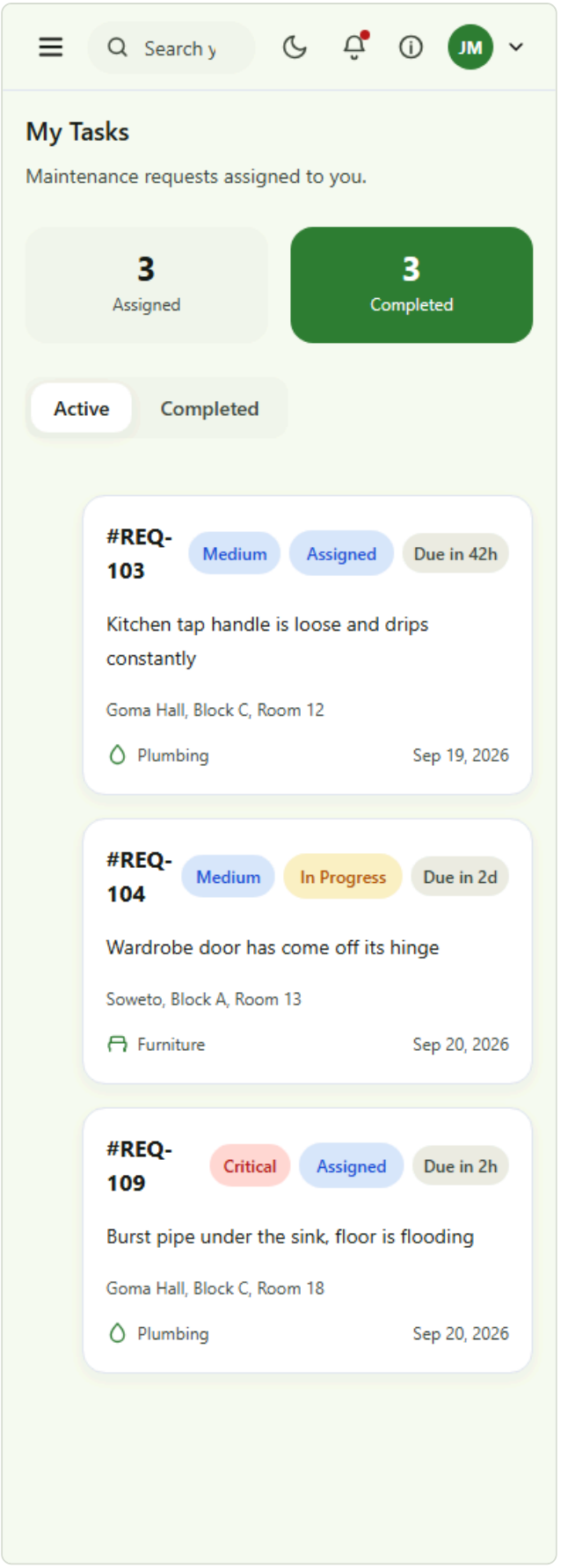
3.1 Your dashboard

- Choose your **status** at the top — **Available**, **On Job** or **Off Duty**. Administrators use this when deciding who to assign, so keep it accurate.
- See how many jobs are **Assigned** to you and how many you have **Completed**.
- **My Active Tasks** lists your current jobs, with their priority and a deadline badge.



3.2 See your tasks

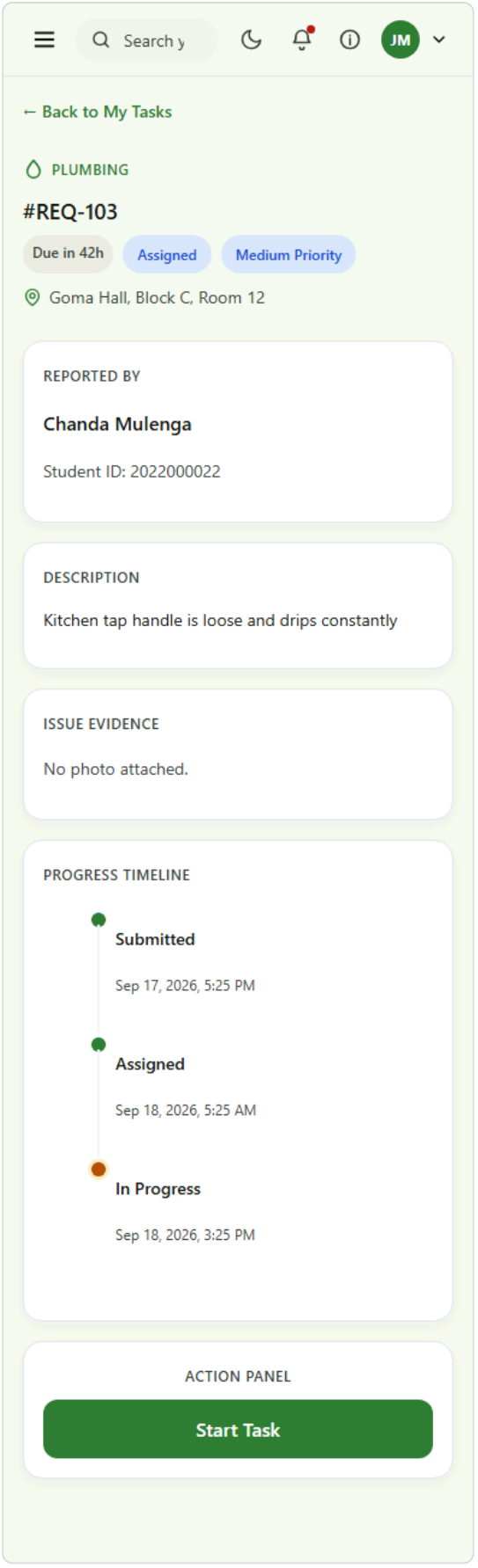
Open **My Tasks**. Each card shows the request number, priority, status, a deadline badge (for example *Due in 42h* or *Overdue 3h*), the description and the location.



3.3 Work on a task

Tap a task to open it. You will see who reported it, the description, the student's photo (if any), and the timeline.

1. When you begin, press **Start Task**. The status changes to *In Progress* and the student is notified.
2. When the repair is done, complete the **Action Panel** (below) and press **Mark as Resolved**.

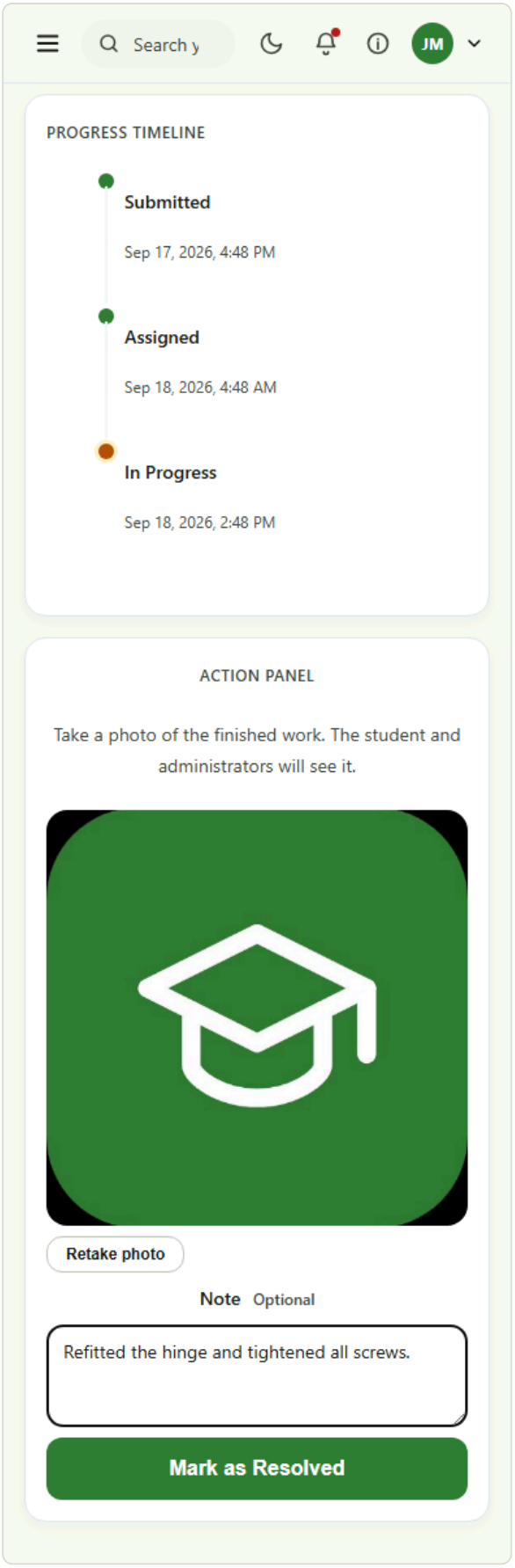


3.4 Add proof of the finished work (optional)

When you resolve a task you can:

- **Add a photo** of the finished repair — tap the camera area; on a phone your camera opens. Use **Retake photo** if needed.
- **Add a note** (up to 500 characters), e.g. "*Replaced the washer and tested for leaks.*"

The student and the administrators will see this under **Work Completed**. Photos are automatically reduced in size so they upload quickly on mobile data.



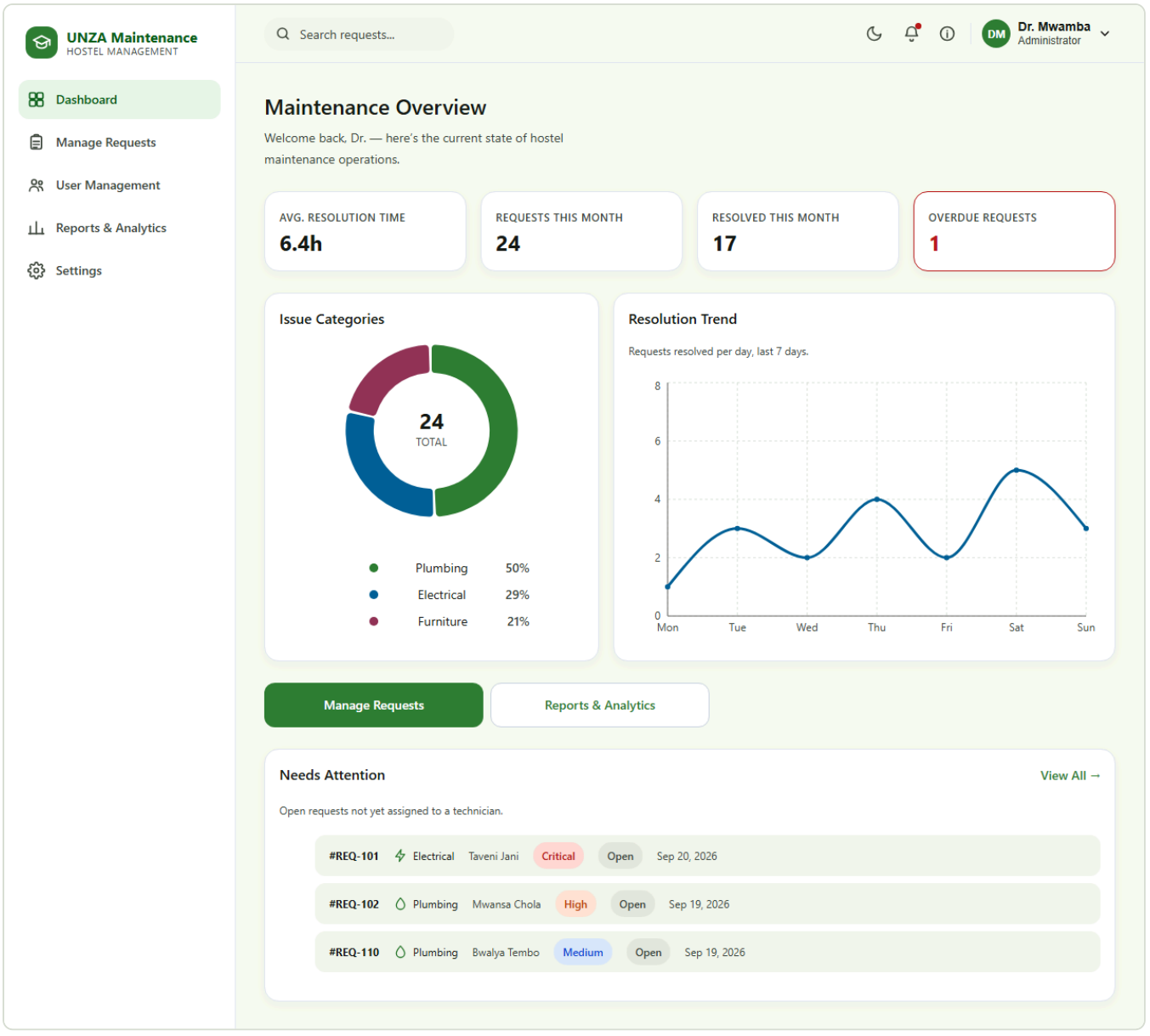
> You can only update tasks that are **assigned to you**.

4. Administrators

4.1 Dashboard

A quick health check of maintenance operations:

- **Avg. Resolution Time**, **Requests This Month**, **Resolved This Month**.
- **Overdue Requests** — turns red when any request has passed its target time. Tap it to go to the list.
- **Issue Categories** ring and **Resolution Trend** chart.
- **Needs Attention** — open requests not yet assigned, most urgent first.



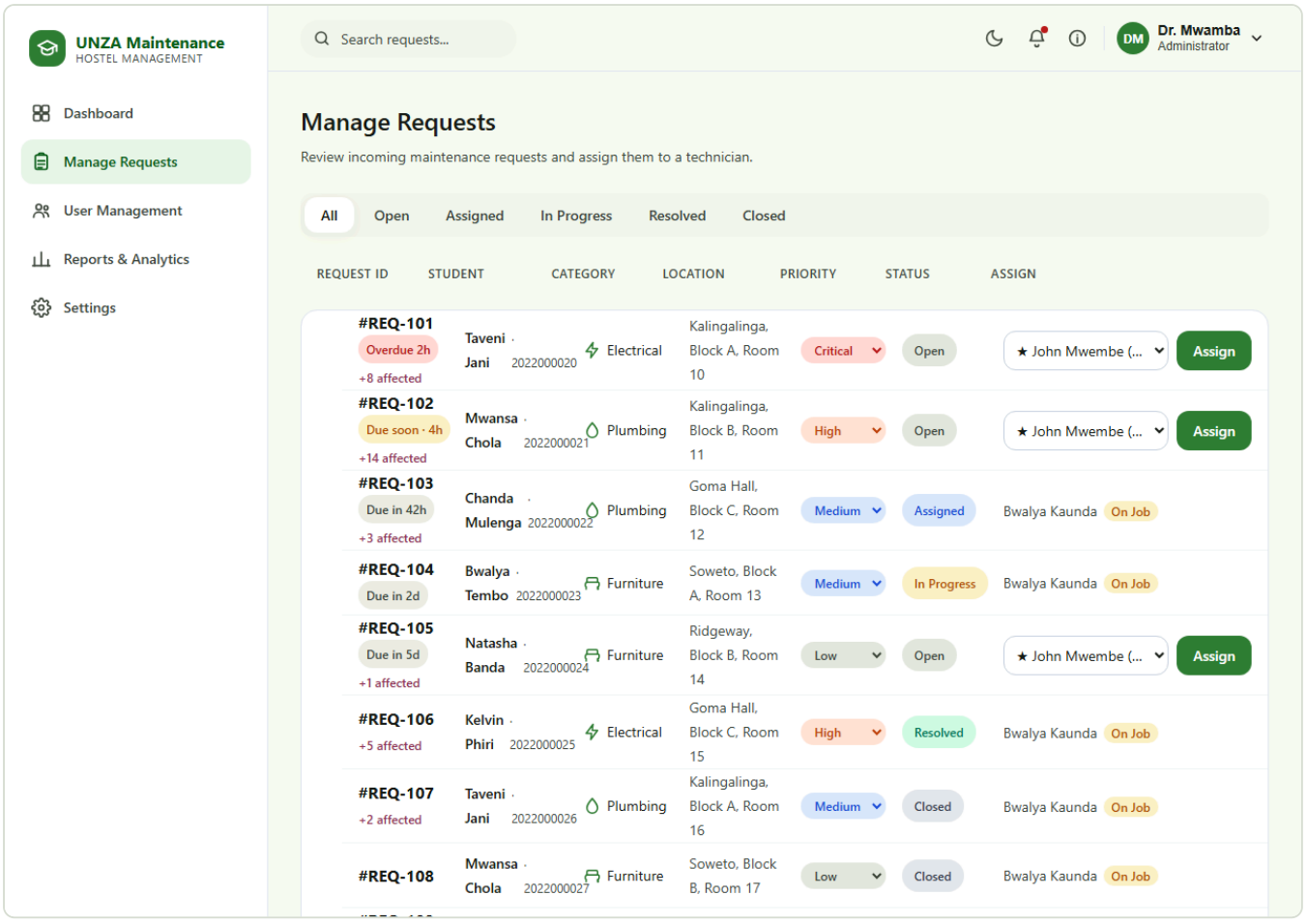
4.2 Manage requests and assign a technician

Open **Manage Requests**. Every request appears with:

What you see	Meaning
Overdue 2h / Due soon · 4h / Due in 2d	The resolution deadline (see section 7)

What you see	Meaning
+8 affected	How many other students used **Me too** on this issue
Priority dropdown	Change urgency at any time
Assign column	Choose a technician and press **Assign**

To assign: open the technician dropdown, choose someone and press **Assign**. The system marks a ★ **recommended** technician — the one who is available and has the fewest active jobs — and pre-selects them, so assigning is usually one tap. Each entry shows workload, e.g. ★ *John Mwembe (1 active)*. People who are *Off Duty* are never recommended.

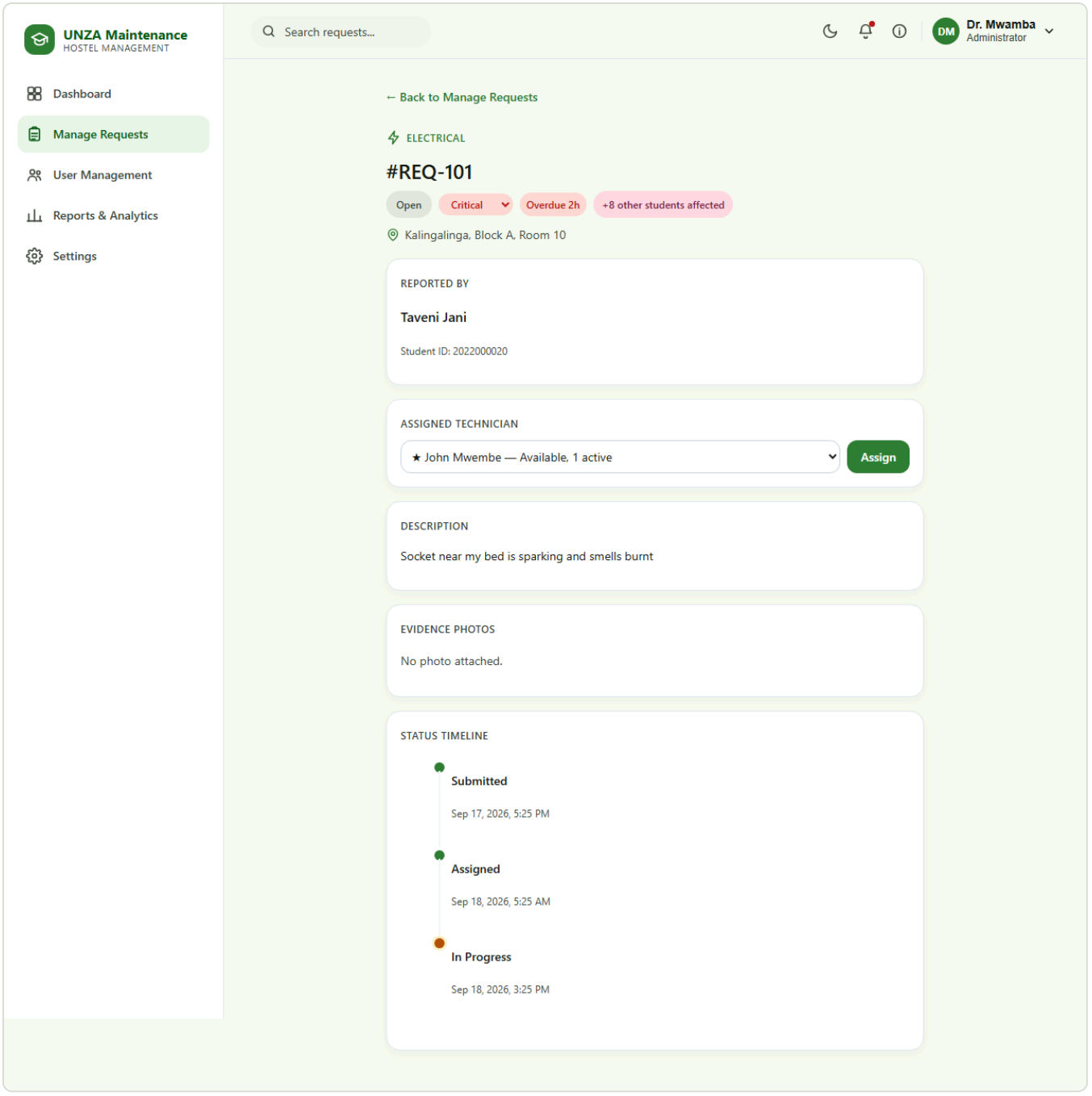


Use the tabs (All, Open, Assigned, In Progress, Resolved, Closed) to filter, or the top search box (by number, description, category, student name or ID).

4.3 A single request

Click a request number to open its page: the reporter, the full description, the photo, the timeline, the technician's **Work Completed** proof and the student's rating. From here you can also:

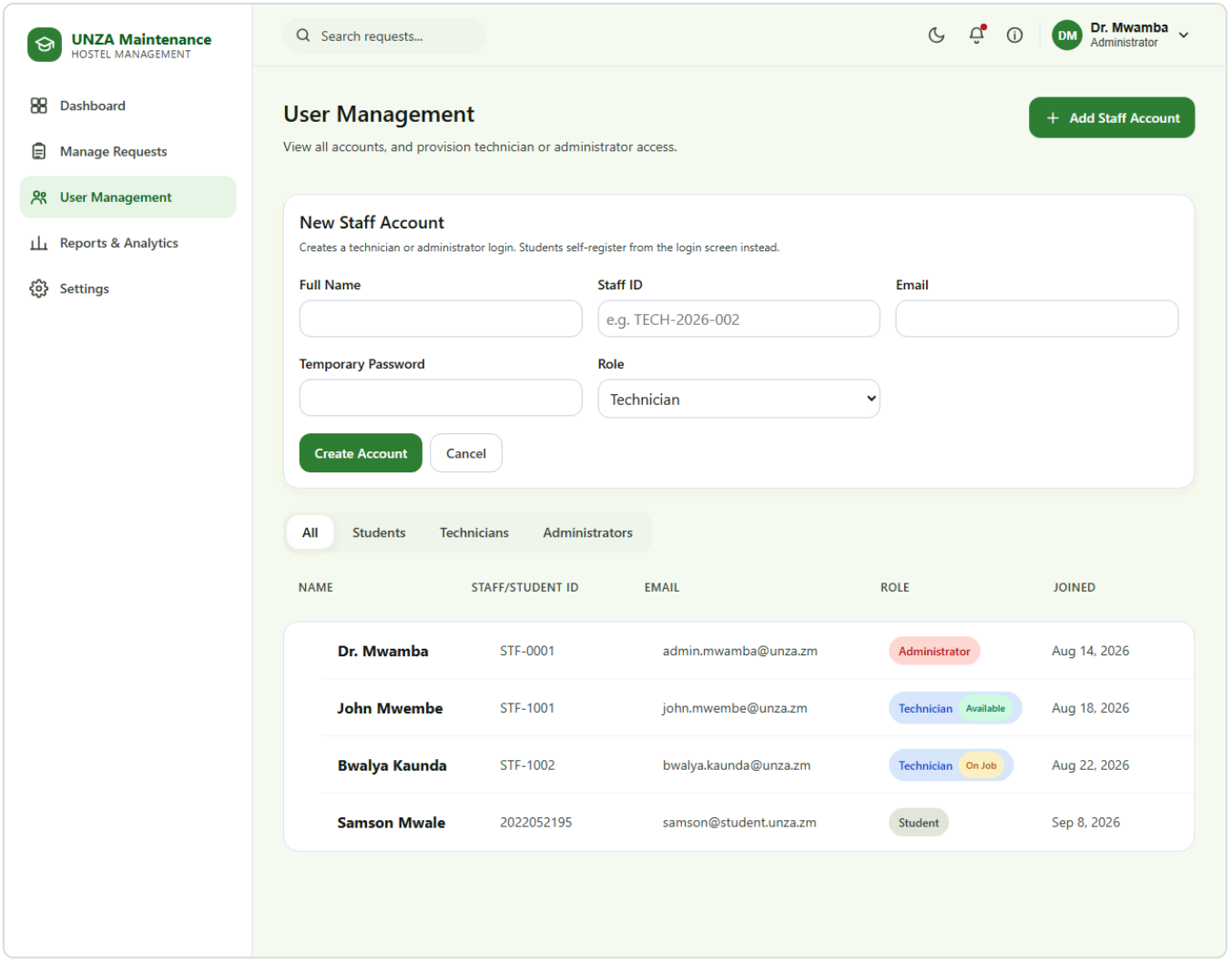
- change **priority**,
- **assign** a technician (open requests),
- **advance the status** (Mark In Progress, Mark as Resolved, Close Ticket).



4.4 Manage staff accounts

Open **User Management** to see every account and filter by role.

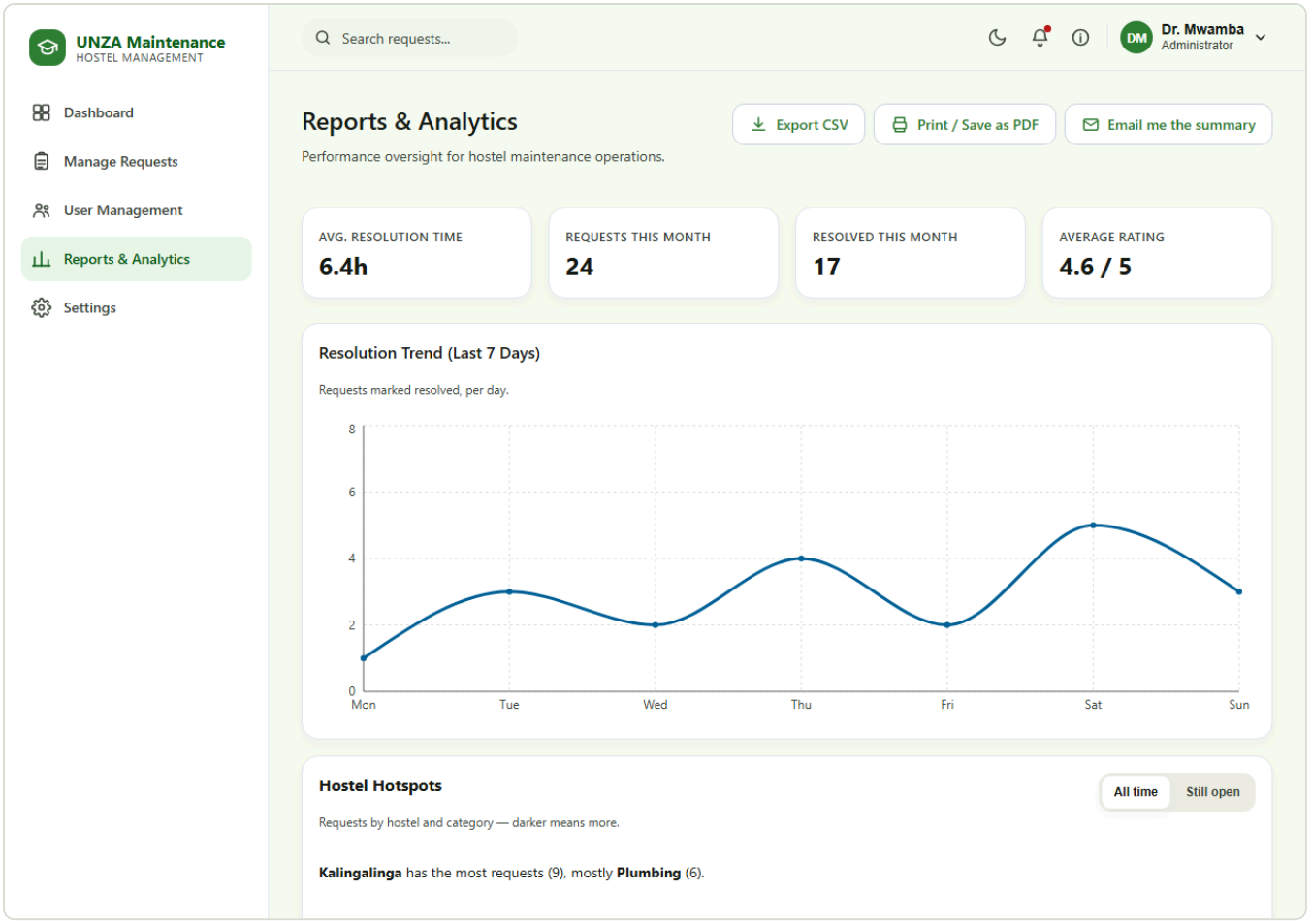
To create a technician or administrator: press **Add Staff Account**, fill in the full name, staff ID, email, a temporary password (at least 8 characters) and the role, then **Create Account**. Give the person their staff ID and temporary password. Students cannot be created here — they register themselves.

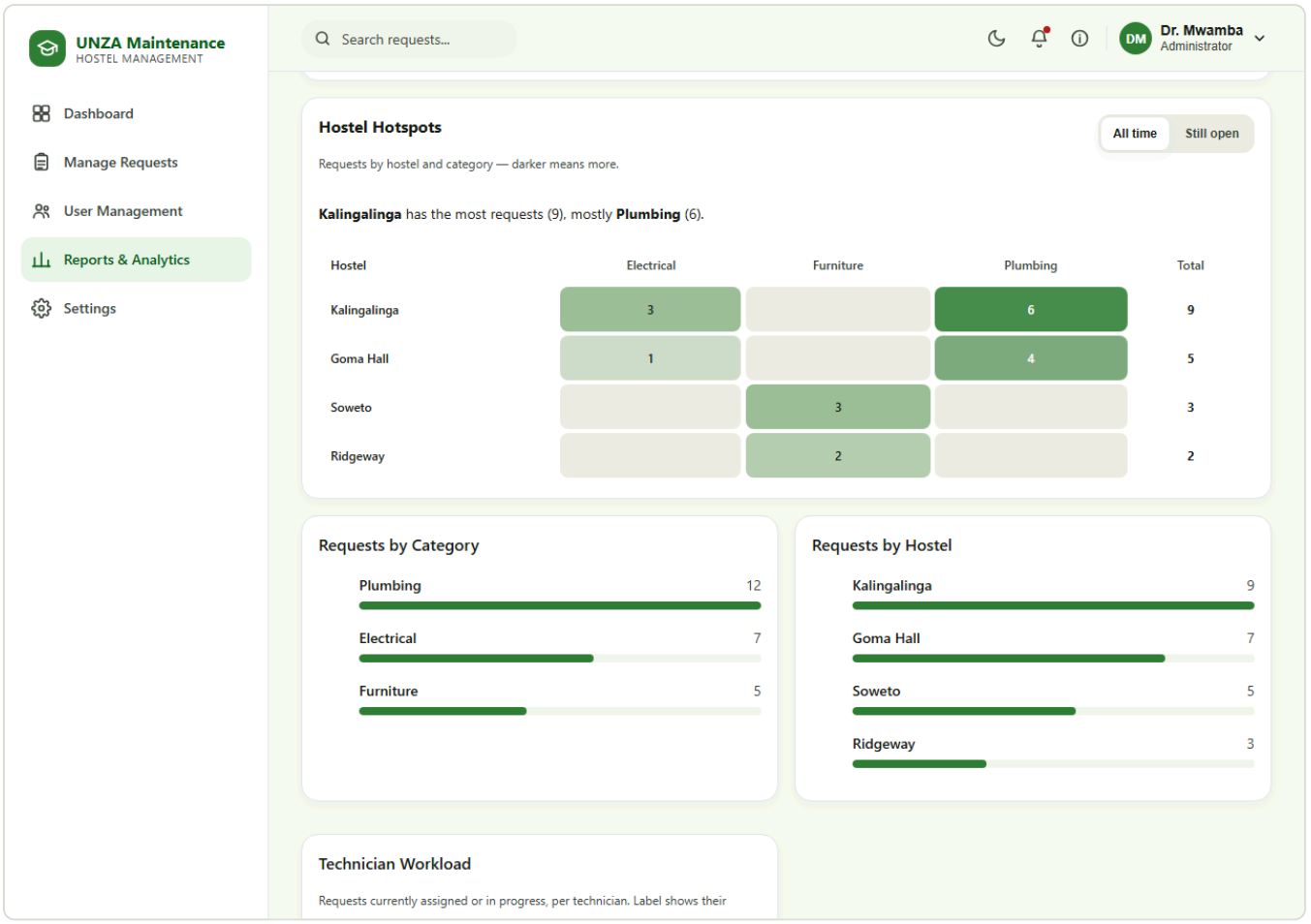


4.5 Reports and analytics

Open **Reports & Analytics**:

- Summary numbers including **Average Rating**.
- **Resolution Trend** for the last 7 days.
- **Hostel Hotspots** — a grid of hostels × categories; **darker = more requests**. The sentence above it names the busiest hostel. Use **All time / Still open** to switch between history and what needs doing now.
- **Requests by Category**, **Requests by Hostel** and **Technician Workload**.





Export and share

- **Export CSV** — downloads every request as a spreadsheet.
- **Print / Save as PDF** — produces a clean printable report.
- **Email me the summary** — sends the weekly summary to your own email address straight away.

4.6 Automatic alerts and emails

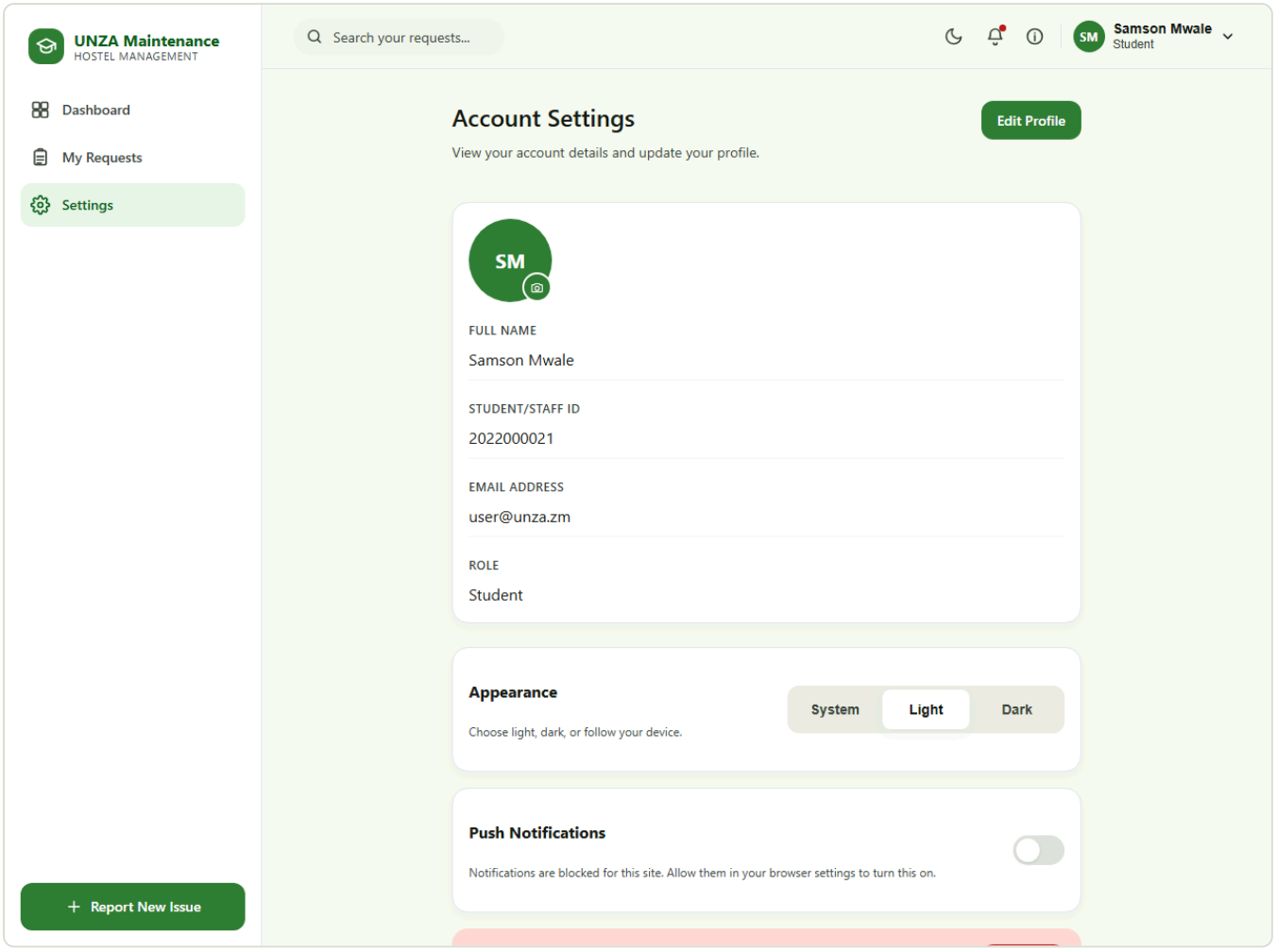
You do not need to do anything for these:

- **Overdue alerts** — the system checks every hour for requests that have passed their deadline and notifies all administrators and the assigned technician. If a request stays overdue you get a **reminder**: every **4 hours** for Critical and High requests, and **once a day** for Medium and Low. Reminders stop as soon as the request is Resolved.
- **New request and status alerts** — push notifications (if you turned them on).
- **Weekly summary email** — every Monday at 08:00 (Lusaka time) to all administrators.

---

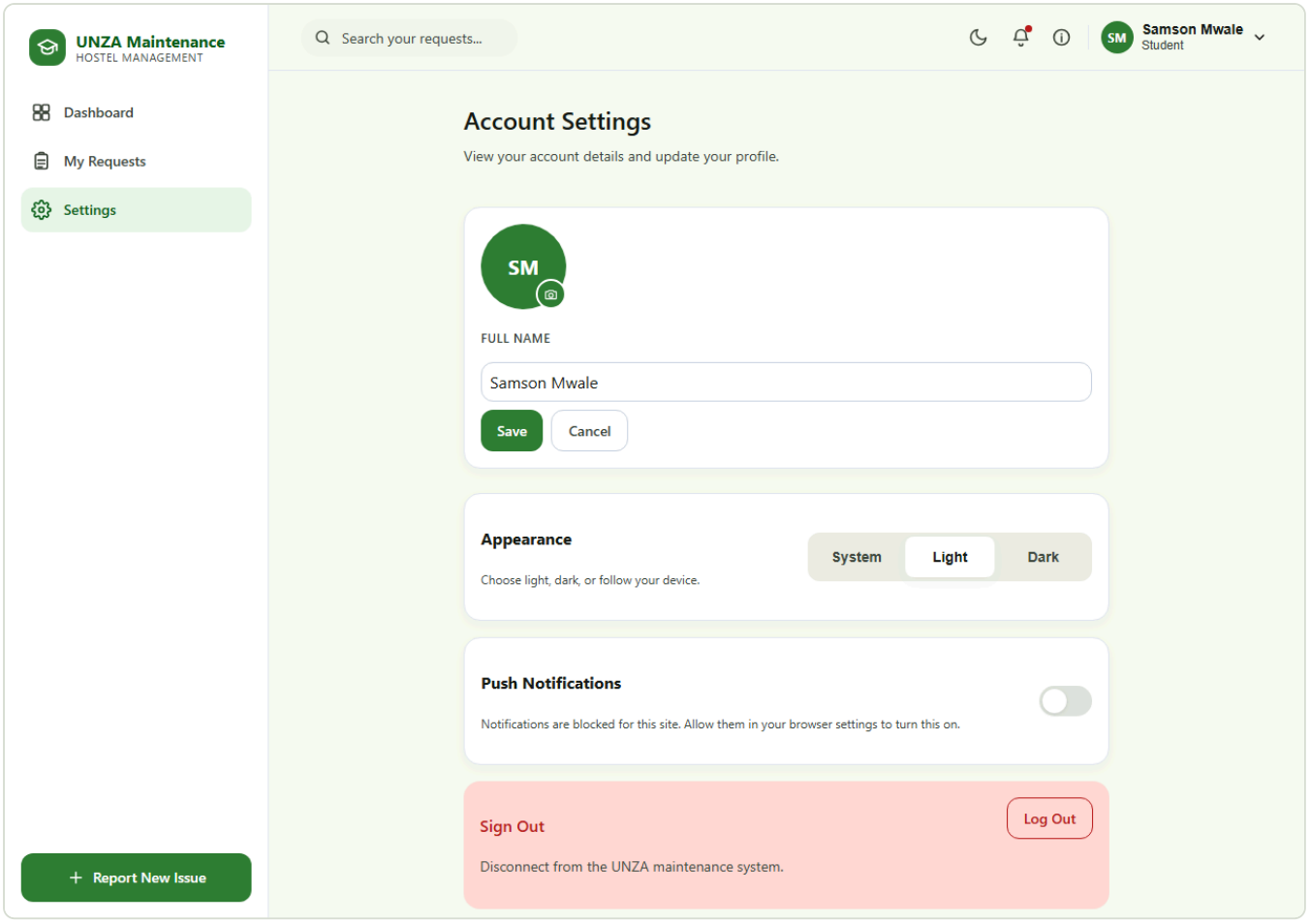
5. Settings, notifications and dark mode

Open **Settings** in the menu.

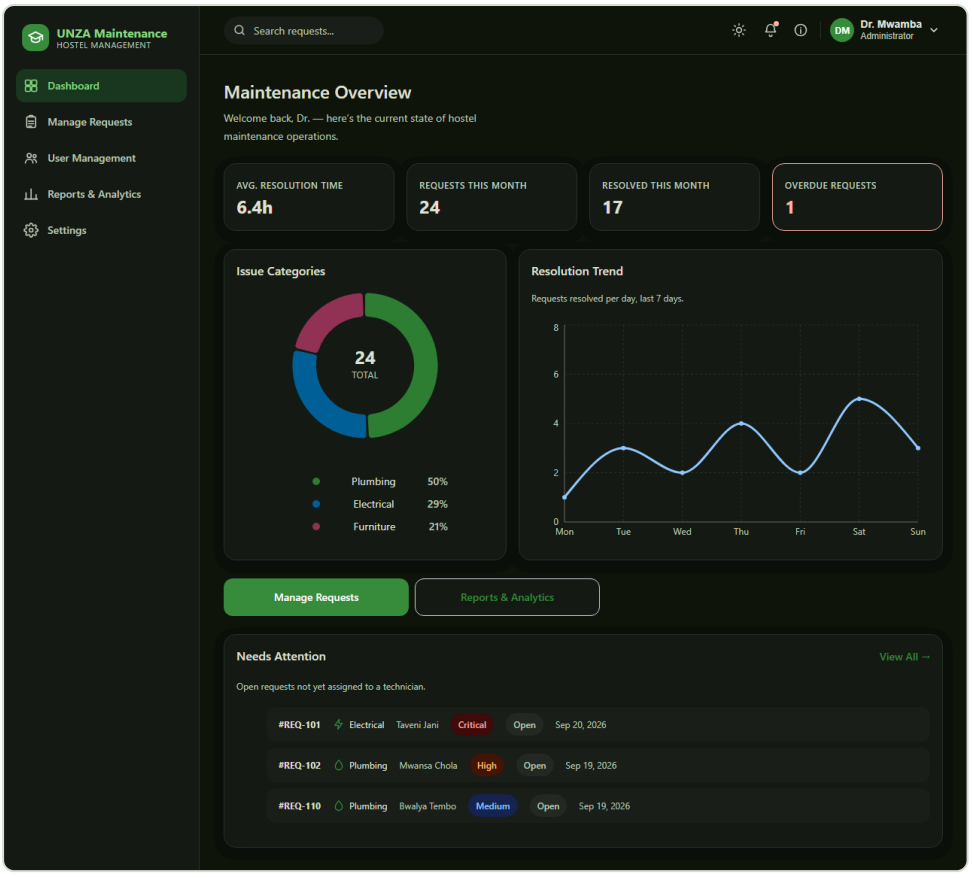
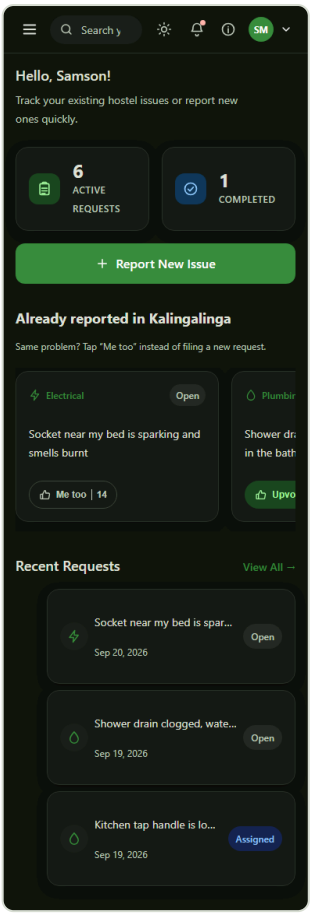


- **Profile** — change your **name** or **photo** (**Edit Profile**, or tap the camera on your picture). Your ID, email and role cannot be changed here.

- **Appearance** — choose **System** (follows your device), **Light** or **Dark**. The 🌙 button in the top bar switches quickly.
- **Push Notifications** — turn on alerts on *this device*, even when the app is closed. You are asked for permission once. If you previously pressed "Block", allow notifications for the site in your browser settings first.
- **Sign Out** — sign out safely. This also stops notifications on that device, so nobody else using the phone receives yours.



Dark mode

Admin (computer)	Student (phone)
	

Who gets which notifications

You are	You are notified when
Student	your request is assigned, or its status changes
Technician	a task is assigned to you, or one of yours becomes overdue
Administrator	a new request is submitted, or a request becomes overdue

6. Working offline

Hostel Wi-Fi is not always reliable, so the app is built to cope:

- **Pages you have visited** still open quickly, even on a poor connection.
- **Students can write a new request with no connection.** It appears in **My Requests** under *drafts* and is sent automatically when you are back online. You do not need to do anything.
- Other actions (assigning, changing status, rating) need a connection; you will see a clear message if you are offline.

7. Meanings of statuses, priorities and badges

Status (the life of a request)

`Open → Assigned → In Progress → Resolved → Closed`

Status	Meaning
Open	Submitted, waiting for an administrator to assign a technician
Assigned	A technician has been chosen
In Progress	The technician has started work
Resolved	The repair is finished (you can rate it)
Closed	Fully completed and filed

A request always moves forward one step at a time; it cannot skip or go backwards.

Priority and target time

The clock starts when the request is reported and stops when it is Resolved.

Priority	Use it for	Target
Critical	Danger or serious damage: sparking wires, flooding, burst pipe, gas smell	4 hours
High	Loss of an essential service: no water, no power, door or window that won't lock	24 hours
Medium	A real fault, but not urgent: dripping tap, dead socket	72 hours
Low	Cosmetic or minor: squeaky hinge, scuffed paint	1 week

Deadline badges (staff)

Badge	Meaning
Due in 2d (grey)	Plenty of time left
Due soon · 4h (amber)	Less than a quarter of the time remains
Overdue 2h (red)	The target has passed — needs attention now
(no badge)	Already resolved or closed

8. Frequently asked questions

I forgot which ID to use. Students use their **student ID**; staff use their **staff ID** (for example `STF-1001`). You can also choose *Log in with email instead*.

Can I edit or cancel a request after submitting it? Not yet. If something changed, contact the maintenance office, or submit a new request with the details.

Why can't I see other students' requests? Your own requests are private. The *Already reported* strip shows only the issue and its status — never who reported it.

Why can't I press "Me too" on some cards? You cannot vote on your own requests, or ones that are already resolved.

Why don't I get notifications? Check **Settings** → **Push Notifications** is on for this device, and that notifications are allowed for the site in your browser. On iPhone, add the app to your Home Screen first.

The page didn't update. Pages update by themselves. If you lost your connection for a while, reload the page (or press **Refresh Status** on a request).

I was signed out unexpectedly. Sessions expire for your security. Sign in again and tick **Remember this device** on your own phone.

Who do I contact for help? Press the ⓘ icon for the status guide, or contact your hostel's maintenance administrator.